

# Elegy V: His Picture



## POEM TEXT

- 1 Here take my picture; though I bid farewell
- 2 Thine, in my heart, where my soul dwells, shall dwell.
- 3 'Tis like me now, but I dead, 'twill be more
- 4 When we are shadows both, than 'twas before.
- 5 When weather-beaten I come back, my hand
- 6 Perhaps with rude oars torn, or sun beams tann'd,
- 7 My face and breast of haircloth, and my head
- 8 With care's rash sudden storms being o'erspread,
- 9 My body'a sack of bones, broken within,
- 10 And powder's blue stains scatter'd on my skin;
- 11 If rival fools tax thee to'have lov'd a man
- 12 So foul and coarse as, oh, I may seem then,
- 13 This shall say what I was, and thou shalt say,
- 14 "Do his hurts reach me? doth my worth decay?
- 15 Or do they reach his judging mind, that he
- 16 Should now love less, what he did love to see?
- 17 That which in him was fair and delicate,
- 18 Was but the milk which in love's childish state
- 19 Did nurse it; who now is grown strong enough
- 20 To feed on that, which to disus'd tastes seems tough."



## SUMMARY

Here, take this portrait of me. Though I'm saying goodbye to you, *your* image will live with me in my heart, alongside my soul. This portrait I'm giving you looks a lot like me now, but when I'm dead, it will look even *more* like me: we'll both be ghostly shadows, then. When I return from my travels much the worse for the wear—with my hands ripped up by crude oars and browned by the sun; my beard and my chest hair all matted; my hair grey from sudden shocks and troubles; my body nothing more than a beat-up sack of bones; and my skin stained with bluish gunpowder—then, if my rivals for your affections tease you for loving a man as ugly and rough as (oh yes) I might look by then, you can show them this portrait so they can see what I used to look like. And you can tell them: "Does the wear on his body mean his feelings for *me* have worn away? Does my value fall in his eyes? Do his weatherbeaten looks reflect a weatherbeaten mind, a change that means that he doesn't love to look at me any more? No! The elegant, refined looks of his youth were just the milk that nursed our love when it was young. But now, we're both grown, and we're strong enough to

eat heartier food—which is only hard to chew if you're not used to it."



## THEMES



### THE PERSISTENCE OF LOVE

About to depart on a long sea voyage, the speaker of "Elegy V: His Picture" offers a portrait of himself to his beloved so that she can remember what he looks like—or rather, what he *looked* like. He knows very well that years at sea are going to transform him: he'll come back "tann'd," grizzled, and battered. But this outer transformation, he feels certain, will not create an inner one. He and his beloved will go on caring for each other even when they're so changed as to be practically unrecognizable. Deep love, in this poem, persists long after the charms of unmarred youthful beauty are gone. The portrait the speaker offers his beloved, he points out, only looks like him "now." It won't look so much like him again until he's dead, when it will resemble his beloved's *memory* of him in his dashing youth—a "shadow" of what he became as he aged. This complicated idea makes a simple point: living people change! Only remembered people and painted people go on looking just as they ever did.

The speaker feels particularly conscious of that fact because he's about to go on a journey that will change him substantially. He's off to sea, on what sounds like a long and dangerous voyage. He expects that he'll come back a "weather-beaten" old "sack of bones," covered with "powder's blue stains"—the marks of gunpowder. The picture he's giving his beloved now might barely resemble him when he gets back (*if he gets back*).

Still, he's not worried that his beloved will take one look at him and flee into the arms of some "rival fool[]"—some younger and more dashing man. That's because their love is deep enough, he says, to endure superficial change. In its early stages, love might feed on "fair and delicate" beauty, but that's just baby food, "milk" for newborn feelings to grow on. A mature love like his and his beloved's can "feed on that, which to disus'd tastes seems tough": in other words, it has teeth, and can easily digest what superficial "tastes" would reject. It can even appreciate a "foul and coarse" old face—one that's as rough to look at as "tough" meat is to chew. Only immature lovers demand perfect beauty of their beloveds; deep love persists through change, time, and loss.

However, readers might note a hint of anxiety here. Not only does the speaker vividly imagine the scene in which "rival fools" rush in to steal his beloved's heart, he prepares a little speech for her with which she can turn those fools away—you know,

just in case. This poem can thus be read as both a statement of faith in enduring love and a touching moment of worry at parting. Perhaps that worry speaks to the speaker's certainty that *he'll* go on feeling the same about his beloved, no matter what.

#### Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-20



## LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

### LINES 1-4

*Here take my picture; though I bid farewell  
Thine, in my heart, where my soul dwells, shall dwell.  
'Tis like me now, but I dead, 'twill be more  
When we are shadows both, than 'twas before.*

"Elegy V: His Picture" begins with a tender goodbye. The poem's speaker is about to "bid farewell" to his beloved and set out on a journey. But before he goes, he gives her his "picture," a painted portrait for her to remember him by. She doesn't have one to give him in return, but that doesn't matter: he keeps an image of her with him in his heart, "where [his] soul dwell[s]."

A painted "picture," then, has something in common with the [metaphorical](#) picture of a person that lives in one's memory. In a sense, the speaker and his beloved will both carry an image of each other with them. These literal and [figurative](#) pictures have something else in common, too: they're quite separate from the person they represent.

The speaker makes that point though another metaphor. His portrait is "like [him] now," he says—that is, it's a good likeness, it captures him accurately. But when he's dead, his portrait will look even *more* like him. That's because then both he and the portrait will be "shadows," dim traces of the person he really was.

A portrait and a memory, then, can be simultaneously a lot like a person and not very much like that person at all. That's because living people—unlike painted people or remembered people—*change*. The portrait and the memory capture someone at one particular point in their lives. But a real, live person isn't static that way. The speaker will one day look quite different from his portrait, and his beloved will one day look quite different from the speaker's memory of her.

No wonder change is on the speaker's mind. As he'll soon reveal, he's off on a long journey, one that might change him substantially. But he's prepared to promise his beloved that, even if he'll no longer look just like his portrait when he comes home, one thing *won't* change: his heart. She'll go on "dwell[ing]" in there right next to his soul, no matter what.

The speaker will make his witty, self-deprecating promise of

romantic constancy over the course of twenty lines of [iambic pentameter](#)—that is, lines of five iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, like this:

Here **take** | my pic- | ture; **though** | I **bid** | farewell

He won't stick to that rhythm strictly. Donne gives his speaker a light, natural-sounding voice through [metrical](#) variations, like those in line 2:

Thine, in | my heart, | where my | soul dwells, | shall dwell.

The first foot there is a [trochee](#) (the opposite foot to an iamb, with a DUM-da rhythm), and it lays a special fervent stress on the word "thine," emphasizing how dearly the speaker will treasure his beloved's image. Then, after two iambs, comes an intense [spondee](#) (a foot with two strong stresses, DUM-DUM) on "soul dwells." As a result, the line strings together three strong beats in a row ("my soul dwells")—an emphatic rhythm to match a passionate sentiment.

### LINES 5-10

*When weather-beaten I come back, my hand  
Perhaps with rude oars torn, or sun beams tann'd,  
My face and breast of haircloth, and my head  
With care's rash sudden storms being o'erspread,  
My body'a sack of bones, broken within,  
And powder's blue stains scatter'd on my skin;*

The speaker follows up his reflections on memory and change with a warning. When he comes back from his journey, he tells his beloved, he's going to look much the worse for the wear.

His description of his future self reveals that he's about to set out on a sea voyage (as John Donne himself did many times over the course of his eventful life). That means exposure to the elements, danger, and hard labor. He'll come back "weather-beaten," he says, sunburnt and worn out:

- His hands will be "with rude oars torn, or sun beams tann'd"—calloused and browned by hard outdoor work, in contrast to the fashionable manicured delicacy one might expect in the hands of a 17th-century poet.
- His beard and chest hair will be so unkempt and matted that they'll look as if they're made of "haircloth," a coarse fabric made of woven horsehair.
- His head will be "o'erspread" by "care's rash sudden storms": in other words, he'll have gone grey from worry and toil. (That [metaphor](#) might also hint that literal "sudden storms" are just one of many things that can turn a sailor prematurely grey!)
- His skin will be marred by "powder's blue stains"—that is, the marks of gunpowder. This line

warns that the speaker isn't setting out on a jolly merchant voyage; he expects to engage in battle.

- All in all, he'll come back looking like nothing so much as a "sack of bones, broken within"—language that paints a picture of a saggy, gaunt old sea dog who can tell when storms are coming by the twinges in his battered joints.

Through this [imagery](#), the speaker presents an almost cartoonish vision of his raggedy future as an ancient mariner. His casual language and goofy metaphors help to set a comic, self-deprecating tone. (Notice, for instance, the way he contracts the two words "body a" into "body'a," an effect that captures the easy speed of everyday speech.) However, there's also a lot of anxiety here. The physical changes the speaker imagines are the effects not just of time, but of difficulty and danger: backbreaking work, storms, battles.

His lightness of [tone](#) here, then, might suggest that he's trying to reassure his beloved, as well as warn her that the pretty face in that portrait isn't long for this world. He'll come back a grizzled old "sack of bones," he tells her, but he'll most certainly come back! It's "When [...] I come back," not if.

## LINES 11-16

*If rival fools tax thee to'have lov'd a man  
So foul and coarse as, oh, I may seem then,  
This shall say what I was, and thou shalt say,  
"Do his hurts reach me? doth my worth decay?  
Or do they reach his judging mind, that he  
Should now love less, what he did love to see?"*

Having warned his beloved that he'll return from the sea looking a lot more "weather-beaten" than his portrait does, the speaker prepares her for another future difficulty: the assaults of "rival fools." In other words, he expects that other men will try to steal her away from him, and that they'll use his battered sea-dog ugliness as a weapon against him. They might "tax" (or chide) the beloved, the speaker warns, over her love for a man so "foul and coarse."

Listen closely to the lines in which he warns her of these "fools":

*If rival fools tax thee to'have lov'd a man  
So foul and coarse as, oh, I may seem then,*

There's a note of bravado in these words: the speaker's dismissal of his rivals as "fools" and his casual contraction of "to have" into "to'have" (pronounced "toove") make him sound jaunty and unconcerned. But there's also just a hint of anxiety in that little "oh" in the middle of line 12. That small cry *could* sound airy: "Oh, yes, I *might* look a little rugged, I suppose." But it might also be read as a sincere sigh of regret, a warning to his beloved that he really "may" look that "foul and coarse"; that's something she needs to be prepared for.

But the speaker and the beloved can both be ready for this future, the speaker goes on. In fact, he's prepared a little speech for her to deploy in case those "rival fools" come knocking. First, she can hold up his portrait, which will *speak* for him: it will "say what I was," attesting to the speaker's dashing good looks in his youth. Then, the beloved can take her turn to speak—and the speaker knows just what she should say:

*"Do his hurts reach me? doth my worth decay?  
Or do they reach his judging mind, that he  
Should now love less, what he did love to see?"*

In a nutshell: "Does the damage to his body mean his love for me is damaged, too?" The implied answer to this series of [rhetorical questions](#) is a resounding "no." The speaker's *body* might be reduced to a "sack of bones," but his "judging mind" will remain unharmed—and that mind will judge that he adores his beloved still.

There's something emotionally complicated going on here:

- On the one hand, the words the speaker puts into his beloved's mouth are a statement of faith in their love. By presenting her with this little speech, he's reassuring *her* that, though their years apart might change his face, they will absolutely not change his love for her. He wants her to trust that he'll still "love to see" her just as much when he comes back.
- On the other hand, he wants to reassure himself that she'll still love *him* just as much! There's something *rather anxious* about preemptively putting words of persistent true love in someone else's mouth—especially when those words speak of a love unaltered by physical ugliness.
- When the speaker has his beloved say that there's no reason that he "should now love less, what he did love to see," then, he's also saying that there's no reason *she* should love *him* less when he's "weather-beaten." (Perhaps he's also delicately reminding her that she, too, will be changed by the years, if not so dramatically.)

In a characteristic moment of Donne's twisty-turny brilliance, these lines are at once a statement of deep, enduring love and an anxious attempt to ward off the thought that love *won't* endure change. The speaker wants to reassure his beloved and himself alike.

## LINES 17-20

*That which in him was fair and delicate,  
Was but the milk which in love's childish state  
Did nurse it; who now is grown strong enough  
To feed on that, which to disus'd tastes seems tough."*

The beloved's imagined retort to the "rival fools" now rises to a

grand [metaphorical](#) conclusion. In her closing argument, the speaker goes on, she can say that the “fair and delicate” beauty of youth is nothing but baby food, the “milk” that nurses a “childish” new love. Young loves, in other words, get their start because of beauty; new love feeds on pretty faces.

But mature, adult love—the kind that the speaker and his beloved share, and will share all the more deeply a few years down the line—is stronger than that. Enduring, adult loves wean themselves off the gentle milk of beauty; they grow teeth, so to speak, and can digest looks that “seem[] tough” if you’re not used to them.

Two metaphors intertwine here:

- Physical appearance is a food. Beauty goes down as sweet as milk; grizzled old faces are “tough” as a cheap cut of meat. (Once again, there’s self-deprecating humor in this vision of the speaker and his beloved as two gristly old steaks.)
- But more importantly, love is a living thing. And while many poets only praise love’s infancy—the time when everyone’s young and fresh and gorgeous—this speaker sees that as, well, infantile. Love can and should grow to its maturity, and that means getting past the easy pleasures of prettiness.

If in earlier lines the speaker sounded a little anxious beneath his bravado, this conclusion feels full of sincere and fervent conviction. The speaker will not and cannot resemble his portrait forever; the beloved will not and cannot be exactly as the speaker remembers her when he comes home. But their love will live on—and will grow and change with them, as a frozen “picture” never could.

really is.

It’s remarkable, then, that the speaker trusts his and his beloved’s feelings for each other to endure unchanged when he goes away to sea. He’ll go through a *lot* of changes then, as he observes in a series of self-deprecating metaphors:

- His “face and breast” will look as if they’re made of “haircloth,” a coarse, dense cloth made of horsehair. In other words, his beard and chest hair will grow long and matted.
- His head will be “o’erspread” with “care’s rash sudden storms”: worries and fears will scatter grey hairs over him like rainclouds. (This metaphor also hints that *literal* storms could be one of the worries that turn you grey at sea.)
- By the time he comes home, his body will be little more than a “sack of bones, broken within”—a metaphor that captures the gaunt, ungainly saggingness of a guy who’s been fighting sea battles and living on ship’s biscuit for too long.

In short, the portrait he gives his beloved now will seem truly ghostly when he comes back: his body will be so transformed (and not for the better) that he’ll look like a different person.

But his physical decay, he insists, won’t make his beloved’s “worth”—her value—“decay” in his mind. A changed body won’t change his heart. He hopes very much that she’ll feel the same way about him, and trusts she will. Their mature love, he feels, has gotten far past some childish need for a pretty face.

He makes that point in what might be the most striking, funny, complex metaphor in the poem. The “fair and delicate” beauty of youth, he says, is just baby food: the “milk” that “nurse[s]” love in its “childish state.” In other words, people might first *fall* in love because they think their beloved is beautiful—but that’s not what *keeps* them in love. As their love grows, it becomes “strong enough” for food that would seem “tough” to someone still drinking the milk of youthful beauty.

Here, physical appearance is like food: beauty goes down as sweet as milk, while leathery old faces are tough meat. But even more meaningfully, new love is like a child. The kind of love that outlasts physical beauty, then, is *adult* in more than one sense. Stronger, wiser, and more capable than young love, mature love is an advance, a gain—not a sad falling-away from the joy of a new relationship.

#### Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-2:** “Here take my picture; though I bid farewell / Thine, in my heart, where my soul dwells, shall dwell.”
- **Line 4:** “When we are shadows both”
- **Line 7:** “My face and breast of haircloth”
- **Line 8:** “care’s rash sudden storms”



## POETIC DEVICES

### METAPHOR

The first of the poem’s many [metaphors](#) links painted portraits to memories. In lines 1-2, the speaker offers his beloved a literal picture of himself, then tells her that *her* picture will go with him “in [his] heart.” A portrait, in other words, is much like a memory, an image of a person captured at a particular moment in their life.

In that way, says the speaker, a portrait is only a metaphorical “shadow[]” of its subject—it’s more like the person’s ghost than like the living person! As the speaker puts it, his portrait will be much more “like” him when he’s dead than it is while he’s alive (even though it’s a pretty good likeness now).

These intricate, interweaving metaphors all get at one big idea: people, unlike pictures and memories, are always changing. So when you try to hold onto a memory of someone far away, you can only cling to a “shadow,” a hazy outline of what that person

- **Line 9:** "My body's a sack of bones"
- **Line 14:** "doth my worth decay?"
- **Lines 17-20:** "That which in him was fair and delicate, / Was but the milk which in love's childish state / Did nurse it; who now is grown strong enough / To feed on that, which to disus'd tastes seems tough."

## IMAGERY

The poem's speaker frankly admits how changed he'll be when he returns from his long sea voyage. With the help of vivid [imagery](#), he describes his future "weather-beaten" self in funny, self-mocking terms, painting a picture of a truly crusty old sea-dog.

First off, he predicts that his "hand"—which, readers might imagine, is currently delicate, more used to holding a quill pen than a "rude oar"—will be "torn" and "tann'd," or scarred and sunburnt from hard labor. He'll be so unkempt that his "face and breast" will seem to be made "of haircloth." In other words, his beard and his chest hair will be so overgrown and matted that they look like coarse horsehair fabric. His head will be "o'erspread" with grey hairs resulting from "care's rash sudden storms" (that is, fits of worry and fear). His skin will be marred with "powder's blue stains"—the marks of gunpowder. In short, he'll be little more than a grizzled old "sack of bones" when he comes home.

These images are at once funny, poignant, and anxious. The changes the speaker describes can't all be chalked up to the passage of time: as his references to gunpowder and [metaphorical](#) (but maybe also literal) "storms" of panic suggest, he anticipates sea-battles and foul weather. It might be wishful thinking on his part to assume he'll come home at all! But if he does, he consoles himself, he can trust that his beloved will feel just the same about that old "sack of bones"—his battered older self—as she feels about the "fair and delicate" young man in the portrait he's giving her.

### Where Imagery appears in the poem:

- **Lines 5-10:** "When weather-beaten I come back, my hand / Perhaps with rude oars torn, or sun beams tann'd, / My face and breast of haircloth, and my head / With care's rash sudden storms being o'erspread, / My body's a sack of bones, broken within, / And powder's blue stains scatter'd on my skin;"

## RHETORICAL QUESTION

As he prepares to leave for his long voyage, the speaker offers his beloved a prepared speech she can deliver in case "rival fools" try to steal her heart. Those fools, the speaker imagines, will try to shame her out of loving a guy as "foul and coarse" as he'll look when he returns from sea. She can answer them, he

suggests, with this string of [rhetorical questions](#):

"Do his hurts reach me? doth my worth decay?  
Or do they reach his judging mind, that he  
Should now love less, what he did love to see?"

The implied answer to all these questions is a resounding "no." The speaker's body might be battered, but his "hurts" can't wound his feelings for his beloved, and his physical "decay" can't eat away at his love for her. The implication here is that, no matter what happens to him, he'll go on loving her—and she'll feel exactly the same way about him.

By putting these words in his beloved's mouth, framing these questions around the idea that *he* will still love *her*, the speaker might be subtly reminding her that she'll change, too—though maybe not as dramatically as he will. Remember, this sequence of questions is meant as a script for the future. The speaker is suggesting that she pose these questions to his "rival fools" one day. But on some level, he might also be planting them in her mind as a way of encouraging *her* to stay true to *him*.

Yet these lines are also romantic and sincere. By posing these questions, the speaker is declaring his steadfast love, not just asking his beloved to do the same for him. The only answer to people who think love is all about physical appearance, he concludes, is to tell them that beauty is just "milk" for a "childish" love to grow on. Real love can handle a "weather-beaten" face, and even come to prefer it.

### Where Rhetorical Question appears in the poem:

- **Lines 14-16:** "'Do his hurts reach me? doth my worth decay? / Or do they reach his judging mind, that he / Should now love less, what he did love to see?"

## REPETITION

[Repetitions](#) add to the fluency and power of this witty speaker's voice.

For example, listen to how he tells his beloved that he'll carry her [metaphorical](#) "picture" (a remembered image of her) in his heart:

Thine, in my heart, where my soul dwells, shall dwell.

The mirroring [diacope](#) here puts the speaker's soul and his beloved's image on an even footing. His memory of his beloved, he suggests, will "dwell" right next to his soul, perfectly matched; the thought of her will *live* in him.

She, meanwhile, will have a physical portrait to remember him by—and to use when "rival fools" try to steal her heart. When these fools tell her that she's wasting herself on a haggard old guy, the speaker says, she can show them the portrait and deliver a speech about their enduring love. His [parallelism](#) here



prepares her to make this retort:

This shall say what I was, and thou shalt say,

Through this parallel phrasing, the portrait speaks, just as the beloved does. The portrait's preserved image of youthful beauty will tell those "rival fools" what *was*, while the beloved will tell them what *is*: the speaker's changed face doesn't reflect a changed heart, she'll say. (Or, as the speaker puts it in another moment of fervent diacope, he will not "love less, what he did love to see" when he looks at her.) The repetition here makes the portrait and the beloved into allies.

Elsewhere in the poem, parallelism just plain sounds good. When the speaker imagines how his hands will look after years at sea, he pictures them:

Perhaps with rude oars torn, or sun beams tann'd,

The echoing phrasing here suggests the wear of time, work, and weather on the speaker's body. Those paired sequences of three blunt monosyllables, each ending with a rough verb ("torn" and "tann'd"), suggest that the speaker's time at sea will beat the beauty out of him, one blow after another.

#### Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 2:** "my soul dwells, shall dwell"
- **Line 6:** "rude oars torn, or sun beams tann'd"
- **Line 13:** "This shall say what I was, and thou shalt say,"
- **Line 16:** "love," "love"

## ALLITERATION

Bursts of [alliteration](#) brighten and intensify the poem's language.

Many of these alliterative phrases describe the speaker's future, weathered appearance. For instance, a pair of appropriately sharp /t/ sounds turn up when the speaker imagines his once-so-delicate hands "with rude oars torn, or sun beams tann'd." (The strong /oar/ [assonance](#) in "rude oars torn" makes this line stand out, too.) The image of gunpowder marks "scatter'd on [the speaker's] skin" uses a similar effect: the harsh /sc/ sounds conjure up a clutter of scars and scabs. And through the insistent /b/ alliteration in "my body'a sack of bones, broken within," readers can hear the speaker getting buffeted and bruised in battle.

Elsewhere, alliteration simply adds emphasis. When the speaker prepares a little speech his lover can use to drive away other men, he studs it with crisp alliteration: he has her ask, "doth my worth decay?" and declare that a mature love can "feed on that, which to disus'd tastes seems tough." These hard /d/ and sharp /t/ sounds make the imagined put-downs sound suitably brisk. The beloved is also to declare that the speaker

does not "now love less"—and here, by contrast, the /l/ alliteration sounds soft and tender.

#### Where Alliteration appears in the poem:

- **Line 6:** "torn," "tann'd"
- **Line 7:** "haircloth," "head"
- **Line 9:** "body'a," "bones," "broken"
- **Line 10:** "scatter'd," "skin"
- **Line 14:** "doth," "decay"
- **Line 16:** "love less"
- **Line 20:** "tastes," "tough"



## VOCABULARY

**My picture** (Line 1) - A painted portrait of the speaker, in other words.

**Thine, Thee, Thou** (Line 2, Line 11, Line 13) - Old-fashioned ways of saying "your" ("thine") and "you" ("thee" and "thou"—"thee" is the object form, as in "I still love thee," and "thou" is the subject form, as in "Thou art looking a little grizzled after all those years away").

**Dwells** (Line 2) - Lives, resides.

**'Tis** (Line 3) - A contraction of "it is."

**'Twill** (Line 3) - A contraction of "it will."

**'Twas** (Line 4) - A contraction of "it was."

**Weather-beaten** (Line 5) - Worn by long exposure to the weather; in other words, looking much the worse for wear!

**Rude** (Line 6) - Rough, crude.

**Breast** (Line 7) - Chest.

**Haircloth** (Line 7) - A scratchy cloth woven from horsehair. The speaker uses the term to make a joke at his own expense: he's imagining that, after years at sea, his beard and chest hair will be so matted and filthy that they'll look like haircloth.

**With care's rash sudden storms being o'erspread** (Line 8) - In other words, "Covered with grey hairs caused by sudden fits of worry."

**Body'a** (Line 9) - Donne contracts the two words "body a" into one here to keep the [meter](#) ticking along evenly: the three syllables of "body a" become the two syllables of "body'a."

**Powder's blue stains** (Line 10) - That is, the bluish marks of gunpowder.

**Rival fools** (Line 11) - That is, the speaker's love rivals, trying to coax his beloved into being with them instead.

**Tax** (Line 11) - Here, the word means something like "accuse" or "criticize."

**To'have** (Line 11) - A contraction of "to have," pronounced "toove."

**Coarse** (Line 12) - Rugged, rough, indelicate.

**Shalt** (Line 13) - Shall.

**Doth** (Line 14) - Does. Pronounced "duth."

**Disus'd** (Line 20) - Unaccustomed, unpracticed.



## FORM, METER, & RHYME

### FORM

"Elegy V: His Picture" sounds less like an [elegy](#) as we'd define it now—a poem of mourning—than a love poem. But the term "elegy" used to be broader, referring to any poem of serious reflection. This particular elegy comes from a sequence that Donne likely wrote as a young man: erotic, witty, and intricate, these poems ponder sex, love, and parting.

There's a sprinkling of mortality here too, though. Over the course of these 20 lines, the speaker observes that the portrait he's giving his beloved will look a lot more like him when he's dead (because then his memory and the portrait will both be "shadows" of what he really was). Yet the rest of the poem is a monument not to death, but to loyal affection. The speaker's insistence that he and his beloved will go on caring for each other even when they're much the worse for wear is at once comic and tender.

Though the speaker makes plenty of jokes at his own expense across the poem's 10 snappy rhymed [couplets](#) (for instance, imagining his beard and chest hair matted into "haircloth" and his body little more than a "sack of bones" after hard years at sea), he also has something serious to say here. To him, the "fair and delicate" beauty of youth is only a kind of baby food, a "milk" that nurses young loves until they're strong enough to endure. Deep love of the kind he and his beloved share is more than strong enough to endure a grizzled head and a weathered face.

### METER

"Elegy V" is written in [iambic](#) pentameter. That means that each of its lines uses five iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm. Here's how that sounds in line 7, for example:

My **face** | and **breast** | of **hair-** | cloth, and | my **head**

As in a lot of iambic verse, this pattern doesn't stay totally constant across the poem; Donne varies his rhythms for effect. For just one example, listen to the jagged sounds of line 9:

My **bo-** | dy'a **sack** | of **bones,** | **broken** | within,

The word "broken" is a [trochee](#)—the opposite foot to an iamb, with a DUM-da rhythm. Fittingly enough, it *breaks* the iambic flow here, reinforcing the speaker's vision of his future self as a

bag of broken old bones.

Note, as well, the contraction of the words "body a" into "body'a," which allows Donne to condense three syllables into two. This [colloquial](#)-sounding, naturalistic effect makes it feel as if the speaker is teasing a little here: he's speaking informally, joking at his own expense. (He does the same thing in line 11, where he contracts "to have" into "to'have," pronounced "toove.")

### RHYME SCHEME

"Elegy V" is written in rhyming [couplets](#). That means its [rhyme scheme](#) runs AABBC, and so on. This jaunty pattern feels fitting for a poem that's as witty as it is tender: each pair of rhyming lines works rather like the setup and punchline to a joke.

Almost all of these rhymes are perfect. There is, however, a single [slant rhyme](#) in lines 11-12:

If rival fools tax thee to'have lov'd a **man**  
So foul and coarse as, oh, I may seem **then**,

That lone off-kilter rhyme arrives in a moment of unease. As the speaker imagines the future, he pictures a time when his love rivals will point out to his beloved that he's looking *pretty rough* after years at sea. The variation in the rhyme, fittingly enough, marks a worry about inconstancy: the thought that other people might try to get between the speaker and his beloved, and just might succeed. The speaker *will* look pretty rough, after all.

But the rhymes get right back on course in the next couplet, as the speaker reassures himself that his beloved will know exactly what to say to such callow remarks. (Indeed, he spends the rest of the poem instructing her in advance on how best to answer those "rival fools.")



## SPEAKER

The poem's speaker is both a passionate romantic and a worried man. About to go away to sea, he offers his beloved a portrait to remember him by—but he's quick to note that it won't look like him for long. His voyage will change him; he might be "fair and delicate" now, a lovely young man, but he'll return a grizzled old "sack of bones."

This change, he feels sure, will not alter his feelings for his beloved, nor hers for him. A love as deep-rooted as theirs, he's certain, has grown past the need for youthful beauty. Good looks are just baby food, "milk" for a "childish" love to nurse on until it can handle tougher cuts of romantic meat.

He sounds constant, mature, and confident—but is he, totally? He declares his belief in persistent love in the context of an anxiety: he worries that "rival fools" will dash in to steal his

lover's heart, and that they'll have a lot to say about how "weather-beaten" his voyage will have left him. He even prepares a dismissive speech for his lover to use when those rivals try to get at her, just in case. All this preparation might hint at a rather touching worry. The speaker is sure that *his* feelings won't change; he just hopes that his beloved's won't, either.

Note that we're calling the speaker's beloved "she" here, even though she's not gendered in the poem. We've made that choice for literary and biographical reasons. In the linked sequence of [elegies](#) from which this poem comes, the speaker is almost always explicitly addressing a woman. What's more, this poem draws on Donne's own seafaring adventures. It's reasonable to interpret this speaker as a version of Donne himself—a notorious ladies' man.



## SETTING

While there's no specific [setting](#) in this poem, readers will likely imagine that it takes place in Donne's own world: England around the turn of the 17th century, an era when one might have one's portrait painted before a journey, set off to sea, and return years later, marked with the "blue stains" of gunpowder.

The speaker's [allusions](#) to a tough life of seafaring might even suggest episodes from Donne's own biography. He twice went to sea as a privateer (in essence, a glorified pirate), once under the command of the Earl of Essex and once under [Sir Walter Raleigh](#). He would have had a detailed idea of what life at sea can do to a man's face—and personal experience of bidding a beloved farewell before heading out for a long voyage.



## CONTEXT

### LITERARY CONTEXT

John Donne (1572-1631) is remembered as one of the foremost of the "metaphysical poets"—though he never called himself one. The later writer [Samuel Johnson](#) coined the term, using it to describe a set of 17th-century English poets who wrote witty, passionate, intricate, cerebral verse about love and God. ([George Herbert](#), [Andrew Marvell](#), and [Thomas Traherne](#) were some others.)

Donne was the quintessential metaphysical poet: a master of elaborate [conceits](#) and complex sentences, and a great writer of love poems that mingle [images of holiness with filthy puns](#). But during his lifetime, he was mostly a poet in private. In public life, he was an important clergyman, rising to become Dean of St. Paul's Cathedral in London.

Donne's mixture of wit, passion, and mysticism fell out of literary favor after his 17th-century heyday. For instance, when Johnson (a leading figure of the 18th-century Enlightenment)

coined the term "metaphysical poet," he did not mean it as a compliment; Johnson saw Donne and his contemporaries as obscure and irrational. But 19th-century Romantic poets like [Samuel Taylor Coleridge](#) were stirred by Donne's mixture of philosophy and emotion, and their enthusiasm slowly resurrected Donne's reputation. Donne is now remembered as one of the most powerful and influential of poets, and he's inspired later writers from [T. S. Eliot](#) to [A. S. Byatt](#).

Like the vast majority of Donne's poetry, "Elegy V" didn't appear in print until several years after his death; his collection *Poems* was posthumously published in 1633. It's hard to say exactly when he wrote this poem, but critics suspect it might have been during his own seafaring years. As a young man, Donne sailed under the command of the Earl of Essex and Sir Walter Raleigh, adding "genteel piracy" to his long, wild, romantic resume.

## HISTORICAL CONTEXT

In his youth, John Donne was a notorious ladies' man with plenty of experience both [breaking hearts](#) and [having his heart broken](#). His sometimes foolhardy decision-making around women came to a head in an oddly touching way: when he fell deeply in love with Anne More, an important official's daughter, he eloped with her without getting her family's permission. This romantic leap of faith backfired on him when his wife's angry father had him thrown in prison.

While Donne was eventually reconciled with his father-in-law, this was a rocky beginning to a marriage that would see many difficulties. The Donnes lived in relative poverty for most of their relationship. They had many children, and both of them suffered from various illnesses. In order to stay financially afloat, Donne was often forced to be literally afloat: he sailed on endless business trips all over Europe, and was often away from home for long stretches of time. While he probably wrote this poem before he knew Anne More, it captures the kind of sad parting that the two would endure over and over again; Donne would write [many poems](#) on the [same theme](#).

It was while Donne was away on one of these many business trips that tragedy struck: Anne Donne died giving birth to a stillborn child in 1617. The heartbroken Donne turned to his religious faith for consolation—and to support his surviving children. Under the patronage of King James I, he became a prominent and successful Anglican clergyman, the Dean of St. Paul's Cathedral in London. In that capacity, he wrote devotional verse [every bit as passionate](#) as his love poetry.



## MORE RESOURCES

### EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [A Brief Biography](#) — Learn about Donne's life and work via the Poetry Foundation.



<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/john-donne>)

- **His Picture** — Admire a famous portrait of Donne in which he poses as a melancholy young lover.  
<https://www.npg.org.uk/collections/search/portrait/mw111844/John-Donne>)
- **Donne's Tomb** — Learn more about another famous "picture" that has survived Donne: his strange, eerie funerary statue in St. Paul's Cathedral.  
<https://churchmonumentsociety.org/monument-of-the-month/the-john-donne-monument-d-1631-by-nicholas-stone-st-pauls-cathedral-london>)
- **Donne's Legacy** — Read a review of a recent Donne biography that discusses his enduring influence.  
<https://www.theguardian.com/books/2022/apr/10/super-infinite-the-transformations-of-john-donne-review-masterly-study>)
- **The Metaphysicals** — Learn more about the Metaphysical poets in this article from the British Library.  
<https://www.bl.uk/shakespeare/articles/john-donne-and-metaphysical-poetry>)

## LITCHARTS ON OTHER JOHN DONNE POEMS

- [A Hymn to God the Father](#)
- [A Valediction: Forbidding Mourning](#)
- [A Valediction: Of Weeping](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 10: Death, be not proud](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 14: Batter my heart, three-person'd God](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 1: Thou hast made me, and shall thy work](#)

[decay?](#)

- [Holy Sonnet 6: This is my play's last scene](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 7: At the round earth's imagined corners](#)
- [Hymn to God My God, in My Sickness](#)
- [No Man Is an Island](#)
- [Song: Go and catch a falling star](#)
- [The Apparition](#)
- [The Canonization](#)
- [The Flea](#)
- [The Good-Morrow](#)
- [The Relic](#)
- [The Sun Rising](#)
- [The Triple Fool](#)
- [To His Mistress Going to Bed](#)



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